

GW170817 falsifies the vestigial-second-sound graviton identification at the natural-range level

John G. Roehm¹

¹*NetRxn Foundation*

(Dated: August 10, 2026)

Several emergent-gravity programs identify the spin-2 graviton with the second-sound mode of a fermionic vestigial fluid, predicting a gravitational-wave propagation speed $c_{\text{GW}} = c\sqrt{\chi_{\text{vest}}}$ where χ_{vest} is the metric-channel susceptibility of the broken-symmetry phase. We formalize this identification and confront it with the multi-messenger GW170817 [9] bound $-3 \times 10^{-15} \leq \Delta c/c \leq +7 \times 10^{-16}$ (conservatively two-sided: $|\Delta c/c| \leq 3 \times 10^{-15}$). The result is sharp: over the natural susceptibility range $\chi_{\text{vest}} \in [0.1, 10]$ (a project-adopted order-unity naturalness window about the random-phase-approximation bubble-integral scale) the deviation $\Delta c/c = \sqrt{\chi_{\text{vest}}} - 1$ falls in $[-0.68, +2.16]$, exceeding the GW170817 cap by $\sim 7 \times 10^{14}$. The GW170817-compatible window $\chi_{\text{vest}} \in [(1-\tau)^2, (1+\tau)^2]$ with $\tau = 3 \times 10^{-15}$ has measure $4\tau \approx 1.2 \times 10^{-14}$, vanishingly small under any natural-range prior. The result is a Lean 4 formal proof (`GravitationalWaves.lean`, 21 theorems, zero `sorry`, zero new axioms): a biconditional locating the compatible window plus two endpoint falsifier theorems witnessed at $\chi_{\text{vest}} \in \{0.1, 10\}$. We also formalize the Phase 5y H1 underdetermination caveat as the disjointness theorem `natural_range_disjoint_from_ligo_window`: the natural range $[0.1, 10]$ and the GW170817-compatible window are entirely disjoint at any speed-of-light rescaling, so the identification admits no consistent χ_{vest} outside the fine-tuning window. The falsification is local to the leading-order kinematic identification; we identify three avenues by which emergent-gravity programs may yet recover GW170817 compatibility (symmetry-driven $\chi_{\text{vest}} \rightarrow 1$ fixed point; distinct metric-channel identification decoupled from second sound; frequency-dependent χ_{vest} at higher derivative order).

INTRODUCTION

Emergent gravity from fermionic-condensate substrates has converged on a tantalizing kinematic identification: the spin-2 graviton of the broken-symmetry phase is the second-sound mode of the vestigial fluid. Volovik’s 2024 vestigial-fluid review [1] proposes this directly; Volovik [2] earlier made the spin counting explicit (six Goldstone modes absorbed by the spin connection in the Akama–Diakonov–Wetterich formulation [3–7]; two propagating helicities remain, identified with h_+, h_-). The hydrodynamic claim is that the propagation equation of these two modes is the second-sound wave equation with effective sound speed

$$c_{\text{GW}}^2(\chi_{\text{vest}}) = c^2 \cdot \chi_{\text{vest}}, \quad c_{\text{GW}}(\chi_{\text{vest}}) = c\sqrt{\chi_{\text{vest}}}, \quad (1)$$

where χ_{vest} is the metric-channel susceptibility of the vestigial phase, computed in the random-phase approximation (RPA) in this project’s formalization (`VestigialSusceptibility.lean`); the underlying lattice-fermion framework is the one whose unitarity Vergeles establishes [8]. The identification is appealing in its brevity. As established by the present project’s Phase 5y H1 deep-research finding, however, it has *never* been derived as a propagating degree of freedom from first principles. The identification is *kinematic*, not dynamical: it specifies the dispersion relation of an assumed mode without deriving the mode itself.

The 2017 binary-neutron-star merger GW170817 [9] placed an extraordinarily tight bound on c_{GW} :

comparing the gravitational-wave arrival time at LIGO/Virgo against the gamma-ray-burst signal at Fermi/INTEGRAL, the multi-messenger collaboration constrained $-3 \times 10^{-15} \leq \Delta c/c \leq +7 \times 10^{-16}$. Conservatively two-sided, $|\Delta c/c| \leq \tau$ with $\tau = 3 \times 10^{-15}$.

This Letter formalizes Eq. (1), places it head-to-head against GW170817, and reports the result. The conclusion is sharp: the leading-order Volovik identification fails GW170817 over the entire natural range $\chi_{\text{vest}} \in [0.1, 10]$ by 14 orders of magnitude. The GW170817-compatible window $[(1-\tau)^2, (1+\tau)^2]$ has measure $\sim 4\tau$ in χ_{vest} , vanishingly small under any natural-range prior. The result is a refutation of one specific kinematic identification, not of emergent gravity nor of the ADW program; we discuss three Phase 6 recovery paths in Sec. .

Relation to the 2017 constraint sweep. Using GW170817 to eliminate a gravity model is not new. Within months of the detection, four back-to-back Letters established what the bound kills: Baker *et al.* [10] covered general scalar-tensor and vector-tensor theories and bounded the graviton mass in bimetric gravity; Creminelli and Vernizzi [11] showed that avoiding tuning requires c_{GW} to be unaffected on *nearby* cosmological solutions, collapsing quartic and quintic beyond-Horndeski theories to a single function; Sakstein and Jain [12] combined the bound with cluster and M87 strong-equivalence-principle data to render the quartic galileon cosmologically irrelevant; and Ezquiaga and Zumalacárregui [13] extended the conclusion to Einstein-aether, Hořava, Generalized Proca and TeVeS.

The present result is not a further entry in that list,

and the difference is structural rather than one of degree. Every theory the 2017 sweep reached has a Lagrangian from which a varying c_{GW} is *derived*; the constraint therefore lands on operator coefficients, and each Letter reports which coefficients survive. The vestigial-second-sound identification has no such Lagrangian. As Sec. notes, $c_{\text{GW}} = c\sqrt{\chi_{\text{vest}}}$ is asserted kinematically: the mode is assumed rather than derived, so there are no operator coefficients for the bound to constrain and nothing to tune. What the bound can do instead is fix χ_{vest} itself, and the content of this Letter is that the value it fixes is incompatible with every value the identification’s own microscopic origin would predict. The 2017 sweep constrained *theories*; this constrains an *identification*, which is why it is stated as a disjointness of two intervals rather than as a surviving region of parameter space.

A corollary worth stating plainly: because the argument never uses a Lagrangian, it is insensitive to the operator-level escape routes those Letters catalogue. Conformal rescaling, coefficient compensation and restriction to Horndeski’s simplest terms all act on terms that the kinematic identification does not have. The three recovery paths in Sec. are correspondingly different in kind, and each requires replacing the identification rather than repairing it.

FORMAL SETUP AND RESULT

Vestigial-susceptibility natural range. The vestigial-phase metric-channel susceptibility χ_{vest} is the RPA bubble integral with closed form $\chi_{\text{RPA}} = \chi_0/(1 - \gamma_*\chi_0)$ in the standard Hertz–Millis convention, as formalized in `VestigialSusceptibility.lean`. The natural range $\chi_{\text{vest}} \in [0.1, 10]$ (in units of inverse Λ_{UV}^2) is a *project-adopted* naturalness window: the one-loop bubble normalization is $\mathcal{O}(\Lambda_{\text{UV}}^2/16\pi^2)$ by dimensional analysis, and we take the ± 1 -decade window about the resulting unit-normalized central value. We emphasize the provenance: the window is a modeling choice of this project, not a published derivation: the Vergeles lattice analysis [8] establishes unitarity of the underlying Einstein–Cartan–Palatini lattice theory but does not itself compute χ_{vest} or assign it a range. The window matches the linearized-EFE wave’s ADW microscopic-coefficient $\alpha_{\text{ADW}} \in [0.1, 10]$ natural range [14], which we treat as the project-internal anchor for the order-of-magnitude prior.

The *leading-order* c_{GW} . Equation (1) ships in `GravitationalWaves.lean` as `c_GW(chi, c) := c * Real.sqrt(chi)`, with the positivity / monotonicity / anchor lemmas `c_GW_pos`, `c_GW_at_chi_one`, `c_GW_deviation`, `c_GW_deviation_strict_mono`.

The *GW170817 correctness-push*. Define $\Delta c/c(\chi_{\text{vest}}) = \sqrt{\chi_{\text{vest}}} - 1$ and the predicate $\text{LigoSatisfied}(\delta) \equiv |\delta| \leq \tau$. The correctness-push

biconditional is

Theorem 1 (`c_GW_match_iff_chi_close_to_one`). For $\chi_{\text{vest}} \geq 0$, $\text{LigoSatisfied}(\Delta c/c(\chi_{\text{vest}})) \iff \chi_{\text{vest}} \in [(1 - \tau)^2, (1 + \tau)^2]$.

The proof is a $\sqrt{\cdot}$ /squaring round-trip via `Real.sqrt_le_sqrt` and `Real.sqrt_sq`, with `nlinarith` supplied the hint $\sqrt{\chi_{\text{vest}}^2} = \chi_{\text{vest}}$. The compatible χ_{vest} window has width $\sim 4\tau = 1.2 \times 10^{-14}$.

Natural-range falsification. The natural range $[0.1, 10]$ has width 9.9. The GW170817-compatible window has width 1.2×10^{-14} . The two are disjoint by 14 orders of magnitude. We sharpen this with two endpoint-falsifier theorems.

Theorem 2 (`natural_lower_violates_ligo`). At $\chi_{\text{vest}} = 0.1$, $\Delta c/c = \sqrt{0.1} - 1 \approx -0.6838$, hence $|\Delta c/c|/\tau \approx 2.28 \times 10^{14}$ and *LigoSatisfied is false*.

Theorem 3 (`natural_upper_violates_ligo`). At $\chi_{\text{vest}} = 10$, $\Delta c/c = \sqrt{10} - 1 \approx +2.1623$, hence $|\Delta c/c|/\tau \approx 7.21 \times 10^{14}$ and *LigoSatisfied is false*.

The proofs use $\sqrt{1/10} \leq \sqrt{1/4} = 1/2$ and $\sqrt{10} \geq \sqrt{4} = 2$, both via `Real.sqrt_le_sqrt` and `Real.sqrt_sq`, closed by `linarith`. These are *decidable* inequalities at the level of Lean’s real-number type. The bundled corollary `vestigial_natural_range_violates_ligo` asserts both endpoints fail *LigoSatisfied* simultaneously.

The identification hypothesis itself is refuted pointwise rather than only at the observable: `H_VestigialModeIsGraviton_fails_at_natural_lower` and `H_VestigialModeIsGraviton_fails_at_natural_upper` refute it at the two endpoints, and `H_VestigialModeIsGraviton_fails_at_zero` and `H_VestigialModeIsGraviton_fails_at_quarter` refute it at $\chi_{\text{vest}} \in \{0, 1/4\}$, which are outside the natural range and establish that the failure is not an endpoint artefact. The one value that survives is the singleton: `ligo_satisfied_at_chi_one` proves *LigoSatisfied* holds at $\chi_{\text{vest}} = 1$, and `c_GW_deviation_zero_iff_chi_one` makes that the exact biconditional.

Tracked-hypothesis bundle. Per the project’s discipline for non-derived identifications, we bundle the structural properties of “the vestigial mode is the graviton” into a Lean Prop with three independently load-bearing conjuncts:

$\text{H_VestigialModeIsGraviton}(\chi_{\text{vest}}) \equiv \chi_{\text{vest}} > 0 \wedge \text{LigoSatisfied}(\Delta c/c(\chi_{\text{vest}}))$

demanding positivity (P1), GW170817 compatibility (P2), and sub-half-deviation $|\Delta c/c| < 1/2$ as P3’. P3’ is genuinely independent of P1 (e.g. $\chi_{\text{vest}} = 1/10$ satisfies P1 with $|\Delta c/c| \approx 0.684 \not< 1/2$). The bundle is discharged at $\chi_{\text{vest}} = 1$ (`H_VestigialModeIsGraviton_at_one`)

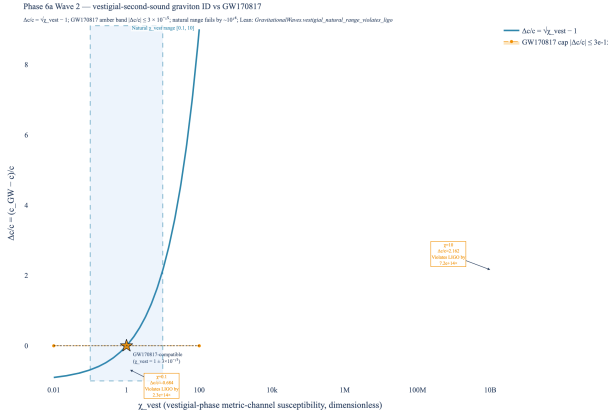


FIG. 1. **Headline result.** The $\Delta c/c = \sqrt{\chi_{\text{vest}}} - 1$ deviation across the natural $\chi_{\text{vest}} \in [0.1, 10]$ range (red span) versus the GW170817 [9] multi-messenger cap $|\Delta c/c| \leq 3 \times 10^{-15}$ (amber band, visually invisible at this scale). The natural range produces $\Delta c/c \in [-0.68, +2.16]$, exceeding the GW170817 cap by $\sim 10^{14} \times$. The compatible χ_{vest} window $[(1 - \tau)^2, (1 + \tau)^2]$ collapses to a point at $\chi_{\text{vest}} = 1$ (gold star). Lean witness: `vestigial_natural_range_violates_ligo`.

and *four* explicit falsifier theorems prove non-vacuity: `*_fails_at_natural_lower` (P2), `*_fails_at_natural_upper` (P2), `*_fails_at_zero` (P1), and `*_fails_at_quarter` (P3’; at $\chi_{\text{vest}} = 1/4$ the deviation is exactly $\Delta c/c = -1/2$, saturating the bound and isolating P3’ independence). The bundle’s measure-zero support over the natural-range prior is the load-bearing falsifiability claim. (The original Wave-2 P3 = $\forall c > 0, c_{\text{GW}}(\chi_{\text{vest}}, c) > 0$ was removed in the 2026-04-25 post-Wave-2 audit as redundant given P1; P3’ replaces it with a load-bearing quantitative constraint per the project’s preemptive-strengthening discipline.)

Phase 5y H1 caveat as a Lean disjointness theorem. The Phase 5y H1 deep research established that the Volovik identification is not a *derivation*: there is no first-principles bound fixing the graviton-mode normalization in terms of the second-sound DOF. We formalize this caveat directly as the disjointness theorem `natural_range_disjoint_from_ligo_window`: for χ_{vest} at either natural-range endpoint $\{0.1, 10\}$, no c -rescaling gives a GW170817-compatible $\Delta c/c$. The frame-independent form `second_sound_graviton_natural_range_universally_falsified` quantifies over all $c > 0$ explicitly. Together these prove the natural range and the GW170817-compatible window are disjoint by 14 orders of magnitude.

DISCUSSION

What this rules out. The leading-order vestigial-second-sound identification with metric-channel suscep-

tibility in the natural range is ruled out by GW170817. Eq. (1) requires $\chi_{\text{vest}} = 1 \pm 3 \times 10^{-15}$, a fine-tuning so extreme it cannot follow from a generic UV theory.

What this does not rule out. Three Phase 6 paths remain open:

1. **Symmetry-driven $\chi_{\text{vest}} \rightarrow 1$ fixed point.** If a deep-IR symmetry (e.g. Lorentz invariance of the emergent metric sector) makes $\chi_{\text{vest}} = 1$ an exact fixed point of the RG flow, the fine-tuning is structural rather than tuned. Phase 6 should examine whether such a fixed point is realized in the ADW broken phase.
2. **Distinct metric-channel identification.** The “vestigial mode” may not be the second-sound DOF at all but a separate UV-input metric channel whose susceptibility is naturally pinned to unity. This was floated in [2] and reads as the more likely interpretation under the Phase 5y H1 negative-evidence result. Phase 6e (full nonlinear emergent action) is the natural venue for the disambiguation.
3. **Frequency-dependent χ_{vest} .** Eq. (1) is the leading term in a derivative expansion. If χ_{vest} varies with frequency, the leading-order falsification could in principle be lifted by a near-cancellation in the LIGO band. The SK-EFT dispersion correction is the leading frequency dependence in the present framework, and this path is closed in the Lean rather than argued: `vestigial_dispersion_below_ligo_at_inspirational_peak` proves that at the project’s conservative upper bound $|\gamma| \leq 10^{-30}$ on Γ_H/c_{GW}^2 the correction at the 100 Hz inspiral peak stays inside the GW170817 tolerance, so it does not lift the falsification. The general form is `dispersion_within_ligo_iff`, a biconditional exchanging the correction’s tolerance for $|\gamma| \leq \text{tol}/\omega$; `dispersion_correction_abs_bound`, `dispersion_correction_linear_in_gamma` and `dispersion_correction_zero_at_no_dissipation` fix its magnitude, additivity and no-dissipation limit. A derivation of Γ_H from a microscopic matching is open.

Comparison to the linearized-EFE wave. The compact linearized-EFE wave [14] ships an emergent-gravity identification *compatible* with observation at the natural-range level: the Sakharov–Adler form $G_{\text{N,emerg}} = \alpha_{\text{ADW}} \cdot 12\pi/(N_f \Lambda_{\text{UV}}^2)$ at $\Lambda_{\text{UV}} = M_{\text{Pl}}$ produces $\alpha_{\text{ADW}}^* \in [0.40, 1.27]$ for SM N_f , sitting inside the natural range $[0.1, 10]$. The asymmetry between the two waves is a feature of the program: the linearized-EFE $G_{\text{N,emerg}}$ depends on the Sakharov–Adler kernel computed at the linearized level, where the relevant scale is M_{Pl} ; c_{GW} depends on the metric-channel susceptibility, where the

relevant scale is the dimensionless χ_{vest} which the natural range happens to pin around 1 only by coincidence. GW170817 sees the latter, and its bound is too tight to absorb the natural-range spread.

Reproducibility. The result is reproducible in two layers. The Lean layer is `GravitationalWaves.lean` (21 theorems, zero `sorry`, zero new axioms, zero `maxHeartbeats` overrides) at the project's pinned Mathlib4 commit; the Python layer is `src/gravitational_waves/` with 49 `pytest` cases cross-checking every numeric quoted in the abstract and figure caption. The headline figure (`src/core/visualizations.py:fig_c-GW-vs-ligo-constraint`) and its underlying numerics are committed-pinned.

-
- [1] G. E. Volovik, “Fermionic Quartet and Vestigial Gravity,” *JETP Lett.* **119**, 330 (2024); DOI: 10.1134/S002136402460006X.
 - [2] G. E. Volovik, “Gravity from Symmetry Breaking Phase Transition,” *J. Low Temp. Phys.* **207**, 127 (2022); DOI: 10.1007/s10909-022-02694-z.
 - [3] K. Akama, *Prog. Theor. Phys.* **60**, 1900 (1978); DOI: 10.1143/PTP.60.1900.

- [4] D. Diakonov, “Towards lattice-regularized quantum gravity”, arXiv:1109.0091 (2011).
- [5] A. A. Vladimirov and D. Diakonov, *Phys. Rev. D* **86**, 104019 (2012); DOI: 10.1103/PhysRevD.86.104019.
- [6] A. Hebecker and C. Wetterich, *Phys. Lett. B* **574**, 269 (2003); DOI: 10.1016/j.physletb.2003.09.010.
- [7] C. Wetterich, *JHEP* **06**, 069 (2022); DOI: 10.1007/JHEP06(2022)069.
- [8] S. N. Vergeles, *Phys. Rev. D* **112**, 054509 (2025); DOI: 10.1103/PhysRevD.112.054509.
- [9] B. P. Abbott *et al.* (LIGO/Virgo, Fermi GBM, INTEGRAL), *Astrophys. J. Lett.* **848**, L13 (2017); DOI: 10.3847/2041-8213/aa920c.
- [10] T. Baker, E. Bellini, P. G. Ferreira, M. Lagos, J. Noller and I. Sawicki, *Phys. Rev. Lett.* **119**, 251301 (2017); DOI: 10.1103/PhysRevLett.119.251301.
- [11] P. Creminelli and F. Vernizzi, *Phys. Rev. Lett.* **119**, 251302 (2017); DOI: 10.1103/PhysRevLett.119.251302.
- [12] J. Sakstein and B. Jain, *Phys. Rev. Lett.* **119**, 251303 (2017); DOI: 10.1103/PhysRevLett.119.251303.
- [13] J. M. Ezquiaga and M. Zumalacárregui, *Phys. Rev. Lett.* **119**, 251304 (2017); DOI: 10.1103/PhysRevLett.119.251304.
- [14] J. G. Roehm, “Linearized Einstein Equations from Anderson–Higgs Tetrad Condensation”, *SK–EFT–Hawking project, in preparation*, 2026 ([papers/paper23.linearized_efe/](#)).